Badminton: Rules and Indian Champions

Introduction to Badminton

Badminton is a racket sport played by two players (singles) or four players (doubles) on a rectangular court divided by a net, in which players hit a shuttlecock over the net, trying to land it in the opponent's court. It is one of the fastest racket sports, with the shuttlecock leaving the racket at speeds of over 400 kilometres per hour in smashes in men's play. The game developed from an ancient game called battledore and shuttlecock, and a version called "Poona" was played by British Army officers in Pune, India, in the 1860s and 1870s. The sport took its name from Badminton House, the estate of the Duke of Beaufort in Gloucestershire, England, where it was demonstrated in 1873. The Badminton Association of England was formed in 1893, the International Badminton Federation (now Badminton World Federation, BWF) was founded in 1934, with nine founder members including India's association, and the Badminton Association of India was formed in 1934. Badminton became an official Olympic sport at the Barcelona Games in 1992, after being a demonstration sport in 1972 and 1988.

Court and Equipment

The badminton court is 13.4 metres long, 5.18 metres wide for singles and 6.1 metres wide for doubles. The net is 1.524 metres high at the centre and 1.55 metres at the posts. A racket weighs about 80 to 95 grams and is made of carbon fibre, with a strung head. Players use light shoes with good grip and wear sports clothes. Events at the Olympics are men's and women's singles and doubles, and mixed doubles.

What Is a Shuttlecock Made Of?

A shuttlecock, also called a shuttle or birdie, is the cone-shaped projectile used in badminton. A traditional shuttlecock is made of 16 overlapping feathers, usually from the left wing of a goose or duck, fixed into a rounded cork base covered with a thin layer of leather. It weighs between 4.74 and 5.50 grams. The feathers give it a high drag, so that it slows quickly and flies in a distinctive way, always turning to fly with the cork forward. Synthetic shuttlecocks made of nylon or plastic skirts, with a cork or rubber base, are cheaper and more durable and are used by amateurs and in schools, while feather shuttles are used in top-level competitions. A set of feather shuttlecocks may last only a few matches because the feathers break. Because of the limited supply of high-quality feathers, there is research on hybrid and synthetic alternatives.

How Many Points Win a Game?

A badminton match is the best of three games. Each game is played to 21 points, and the rally-point system is used, which means a point is scored on every rally, whoever served. The side that wins a rally scores a point and serves next. A player or pair must win a game by two clear points, so if the score reaches 20-all, play continues until one side has a two-point lead, but at 29-all, the side that scores the 30th point wins the game. The winner of the previous game serves first in the next game, and at the end of each game, players change ends, with a short interval of 60 seconds when the leader reaches 11 points, and a 2-minute break between games. The rally-point system to 21 was introduced in 2006, replacing an older system in which only the serving side could score and games were to 15 points for men's singles and 11 for women's singles. The serve must be hit underhand with the shuttle struck below the waist, and the server's feet must remain on the ground, diagonally across to the opposite service court. Faults include hitting the shuttle into the net or outside the lines, hitting it twice, touching the net with the racket or body, and obstructing the opponent.

Basic Shots and Strategy

The main shots are the serve, the clear (a high deep shot to the back of the court), the drop shot (a soft shot that falls just over the net), the smash (a powerful downward shot), the drive (a flat fast shot), the net shot and the lob. Success depends on footwork, stamina, reflexes and tactical thinking.

Name Two Indian Olympic Medallists in Badminton

Two Indian Olympic medallists in badminton are Saina Nehwal and P. V. Sindhu. Saina Nehwal, from Hyderabad, won the bronze medal in women's singles at the 2012 London Olympics, the first Indian badminton Olympic medal, and also reached world number one in 2015. Pusarla Venkata Sindhu, from Hyderabad, won the silver medal at the 2016 Rio Olympics, and the bronze at the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, becoming the first Indian woman to win two individual Olympic medals. She also won the BWF World Championships gold in Basel in 2019, and silvers and bronzes in other years. Lakshya Sen reached the semi-final at the 2024 Paris Olympics and finished fourth, narrowly missing a medal.

Other Indian Champions

Prakash Padukone won the All England Open in 1980, and was the first Indian to do so, and became the world number one in 1980. Pullela Gopichand won the All England title in 2001 and is a coach who trained Saina Nehwal, Sindhu, Kidambi Srikanth and others at his academy in Hyderabad. Kidambi Srikanth became world number one in 2018. The India men's team won the Thomas Cup for the first time in 2022 in Bangkok, defeating 14-time champions Indonesia 3-0, with players such as Lakshya Sen, Kidambi Srikanth, H. S. Prannoy and the doubles pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty. The doubles pair won the Asian Games gold medal in 2023 at Hangzhou and rose to world number one in 2023. Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa won the Commonwealth Games gold in doubles in 2010. Tamil Nadu has produced fine para-badminton players: at the Paris 2024 Paralympics, Thulasimathi Murugesan won a silver medal and Manisha Ramadass and Nithya Sre Sivan won bronze medals, with Nitesh Kumar winning gold. Pramod Bhagat won the men's singles gold at the Tokyo 2020 Paralympics.

Benefits of Badminton

Badminton improves cardiovascular fitness, agility, reflexes, hand-eye coordination and stamina, burns many calories, and can be played by all ages and in small spaces, at low cost. Badminton is hugely popular in Chennai and across Tamil Nadu, with indoor courts and academies. The Premier Badminton League and other leagues have raised its visibility.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include the cost of shuttlecocks, training facilities and a need for more coaches. India's success at the Thomas Cup, the Asian Games and the Olympics, together with the growing academies, has made the future bright.

Quick Facts

- A badminton game is played to 21 points with rally scoring, won by two clear points up to a cap of 30; a match is the best of three games.
- A shuttlecock is made of 16 goose or duck feathers fixed in a cork base covered with leather.
- Saina Nehwal (bronze, 2012) and P. V. Sindhu (silver, 2016; bronze, 2020) are India's Olympic badminton medallists.
- India won the Thomas Cup for the first time in 2022.
- Badminton became an Olympic sport in 1992.